

Instagram Discourse Analysis - @lyss.rosey

Netnography Working Document

1. How This Dataset Came to Exist

This dataset was brought to my attention by a fellow student familiar with my research topic. A parenting influencer (@lyss.rosey) had posted a short video about an age-scaled birthday gift contribution format (\$1 per year of the child's age), a concept sitting at the heart of my capstone research.

The comment section had delivered not just reactions but a living negotiation of gift-giving norms: fears, proposals, experiments, objections, and counter-arguments.

2. The Dataset: Context and Scale

The account (@lyss.rosey) has 14,600 followers. The gifting post has received 1.9 million views, approximately 130 times the creator's normal audience reach. This ratio matters: the content was algorithmically amplified because engagement signals were unusually strong. The post's reach far exceeded the creator's normal audience, suggesting the topic itself activated considerable resonance rather than being driven by platform size alone.

The full dataset spans three Reels published within six days of each other (13-19 March 2026), with two further posts following over the next seven weeks:

- Post 1: The original video introducing the age-scaled contribution format. 1.9M views, 89,000 likes, 1,970 comments.
- Post 2: A curated follow-up video featuring the creator's favourite comments from Post 1, published the following day (14 March 2026).
- Post 3: A further video on party bag alternatives, prompted by comment themes emerging from Posts 1 and 2.

The 7-week lifespan is itself significant. Most viral social media content peaks and fades within days. This dataset continued generating substantial engagement across seven weeks, suggesting the topic has sustained cultural relevance rather than momentary novelty.

Methodological note. This analysis draws on a purposive sample of high-engagement comments from Posts 1 and 2, read until thematic saturation was reached. Post 2 was treated as a researcher-curated sample: the creator herself selected her "best comments", providing a first-pass thematic filter validated by community endorsement. Negative comments were specifically sought in Post 1 to ensure the resistant minority was represented. All commenters are anonymised. Ethics approval for secondary analysis of publicly available social media data was obtained in accordance with LIS institutional guidelines.

3. One Comment Names the Problem

"Can you share what invitations actually look like with these ideas? I feel like it's still awkward to genuinely write them."

Post 2 comment

This comment - unprompted, from a stranger on Instagram - voiced the capstone research question in plain language. The barrier is the moment of writing the invitation: finding words that make an unconventional ask feel normal rather than transgressive.

4. What the Community Endorses: Positive Themes

4a. The Norm is Already Shifting

Multiple comments reported having tried alternative formats and found them successful. One parent described a two-year natural experiment: in year one, "please no gifts" produced 50% compliance; in year

two, adding specific alternatives (“a handmade card, a favourite book, or \$5 towards the adventure fund”) produced near-total compliance with richer outcomes. The controlled nature of this observation - same family, same social network, different wording - is striking. Parents need to know what to do instead.

4b. Experiential and Collective Alternatives Resonate Most

The three most liked comments in the entire dataset were not about financial logistics. They were about alternatives that preserve social warmth while transforming the material exchange:

“We did a book swap for the kiddos. Everyone got a take home goodie, no purchase required, and we didn’t have a ton of extra gifts/clutter to bring home.”

2,078 likes - highest-endorsed comment in the dataset

“Our birthday gift will always be a gift card to an ice cream shop with a note about ‘go on an ice cream date with mom or dad!’ Because we truly believe that the best thing we can encourage and help facilitate is time with their parent.”

1,958 likes

“895 lbs of food instead of gifts. He was so proud bringing and physically unloading all that food to our local food pantry. Truly, way better than all the toys in the world.”

1,190 likes - cat food for animal shelter version

In each case, the child is not simply a passive beneficiary of a transaction. They experience something that carries social or community meaning.

→ Design implication: Current invitation = parents arrange, guests contribute, child receives. The most resonant alternatives in the dataset shift this framing. A design iteration worth exploring: how does the invitation frame what the child will do with the collective gift, not just what guests will contribute?

4c. The Creator’s Own Curation: Post 2

The creator’s summary of Post 2 comments is worth quoting as a curatorial act in its own right. She identified five categories as her favourites: guests bringing supplies for a local shelter; collecting donations for a charity; doing a book exchange; contributing to one meaningful gift; and - her personal favourite - the “friendship garden”:

“Such a sweet way to make a memory and avoid the pile of plastic toys that get forgotten about in a week. Each guest brought a plant and they planted them together at the party.”

Creator’s summary, Post 2

The friendship garden is the most complete solution in the entire dataset. It involves no financial transaction, preserves the collective ritual moment (planting together at the party), gives the child a lasting physical memento, and carries an environmental message naturally rather than didactically. It is worth noting that the creator - whose audience endorsed her original financial contribution format - chose a non-financial alternative as her personal favourite. The community’s appetite is not specifically for pooled money; it is for meaningful alternatives to consumerist gifting.

→ Design implication: A platform offering only a contribution link may be solving a narrower problem than the one parents actually have. A menu of formats - contribution link, book swap, charity donation, experiential gift - would serve a wider range of families and contexts.

4d. Institutional Legitimacy Reduces Friction

“I asked attendees to donate directly to my child’s 529 college plan instead of gifts. Fidelity has a link I provide in the invitation. It’s worked very well.”

88 likes

This comment introduces a design variable my survey did not test: the platform hosting the contribution link. A Fidelity link (institutional, financial, future-oriented) lands differently from a generic payment link. The institutional frame absorbs some of the face-threat by repositioning the ask as responsible planning rather than requesting money. The EchoAge platform (referenced in another comment) takes this further: guests donate, half goes to the birthday child, half to a charity of the child's choice, and guests receive tax receipts. The platform does the normative work that the invitation alone cannot.

→ Design implication: The platform behind the link is part of the design problem. Legitimacy, purpose, and recipient framing all affect whether the ask feels appropriate or transactional.

5. A Nervous Parent's Story

One exchange in Post 2 deserves its own section. A parent shared:

"I'm so nervous to try to start this!!! I tried adding this to my daughter's invite: 'No gifts needed - just come ready to play, your presence is the real win of the day! But if you'd like to bring a little something [daughter's name]'s way, a card, a drawing, or \$8 for 8 would make her day.' I circulated it around to a couple of my family and friends, and they said it sounded like an admission fee for the party so I took it off."

Post 2 comment

The parent drafted a warm, age-scaled, opt-out-inclusive invitation. She sought social validation. Two people objected. She removed it.

The replies restored her:

"Really?! Oh my gosh I totally disagree. Anyone bringing a gift would be spending more than \$8!!! The moms at our school have been THRILLED about it!!"

Community reply, 2 likes

"I'm gonna be brave and try again next year!!! 😊"

Parent's reply

She needed one voice of lived experience, not a better template - and the community provided it in two sentences. This suggests a social proof layer could matter: testimonials, evidence that others have tried this and it worked.

→ Design implication: The invitation template is necessary but not sufficient. The platform might also need to provide the social confidence to send it - through testimonials, community stories, or a simple counter showing how many parents have already sent this invitation.

6. What the Community Resists: Negative Themes

Negative comments are a minority in this dataset - consistently buried under higher-engagement positive responses - but they cluster around three coherent objections worth taking seriously as design challenges.

6a. The Money Taboo

"It's tacky. It's asking for money. It's rude. Just on principle I wouldn't bring the cash."

8 likes

This objection received 8 likes. The immediate reply - "Rude to save the guests time and money?" - received 152 likes, completely overwhelming the original. The community is not persuaded by this framing. But the

objection matters because it represents the ambient cultural assumption that financial requests are inherently inappropriate in social gift contexts.

→ Design implication: The opt-out is not a legal disclaimer - it is the primary social technology that makes the ask feel safe. It must be prominent, warm, and unambiguous.

6b. The Moral Education Objection

"The entire point of getting a gift is to teach your child to do something thoughtful for someone else. To take time to think about that child to get them something they may like. This is downright lazy parenting."

101 likes - most endorsed negative comment

This was the most liked negative comment, appearing twice with identical wording and 101 likes each time. The objection defends the gift-selection process - the act of choosing, the thinking about another's preferences as a social and moral education in itself. A counter-comment (also well-liked) turned the argument on its head: "Money is a great way to teach a child about personal finances and giving them the opportunity to make a financial choice independently" - accepting the moral education premise and offering a better version of it.

Importantly, the same commenter also wrote aggressive follow-up replies defending their position - suggesting the 141 replies this comment generated were partly inflated by one vocal participant rather than 141 independent voices. The 101 likes remain as the more reliable signal of genuine endorsement.

6c. The Admission Fee Perception

Several comments - including the nervous parent's family and friends - perceived a contribution ask as equivalent to charging an entry fee for the party. This is a different objection from the money taboo: it conflates the gift with the cost of attendance, implying the child's friendship is conditional on payment. The "no obligation" framing directly addresses this., but only if it is believed. Credibility requires that the opt-out feels genuine, not performative.